

HEMANT KARKARE'S DEATH INCONVENIENT TRUTHS

His widow asks some troubling questions

A year after Maharashtra Anti-Terror Squad chief Hemant Karkare was gunned down on 26/11, his wife Kavita continues to be on a mission to find the truth about her husband's death. She wants to know what happened to Karkare's bulletproof jacket that went missing after he was shot and the reasons for several police lapses. The reply to an RTI application filed on the whereabouts of the jacket simply said that it was missing. The response compelled the Maharashtra Government to order a probe into the case. Kavita started gathering facts about the incident soon after politicians accused her husband of acting hastily that night. She claims that Karkare, along with additional commissioner of police Ashok Kamte and inspector Vijay Salaskar, were planning a strategy at Cama Hospital for 40 minutes. Kavita says they had asked for back-up but did not get it in those 40 minutes. She has also alleged that her husband was injured and left unattended to for over 40 minutes and was not taken to hospital on time. For the last one year, Kavita has not only called for better weapons and training for the police force, but has also been a fierce critic of the Pradhan Committee Report which gave a clean chit to the police. She has also held the state Government responsible for providing poor quality equipment to the police. Kavita says she will not be at ease till she has all the answers. Her journey for truth is likely to be a long and painful one.

by Nishika Patel



SHARAD PAUL/www.indiatodayimages.com



VIJAYADEVI KUSHWAHA, 43, Shot at CST

COMPENSATION DELIVERED: PMRF (Rs 1 lakh), state Government (Rs 50,000), Central Railway (Rs 15,000)

COMPENSATION UNDELIVERED: Union Home Ministry funds of Rs 1 lakh still pending

One of the many hapless victims of the 26/11 terror attack on Mumbai, Vijayadevi Kushwaha was shot through her thigh at the CST. With an injured leg, Kushwaha limped her way across to St. George Medical College for first aid. Apart from dealing with her own injuries, Kushwaha also had to cope with the trauma of the death of her younger brother in the terror attack. She was treated for bullet wounds at the J.J. Hospital for over six months, but a year after the incident, Kushwaha finds it difficult to walk or do any household chores. Her husband Ramkomal, an autorickshaw driver, divides times between Mumbai and his village in Ghazipur district of Uttar Pradesh where he has to take care of an ailing father. With added medical expenses, Kushwaha can afford no more than a derisory existence in a shanty in suburban Mumbai. "The compensation amount is still pending in several cases because bank account details are being re-verified. We are doing all of this," says Mumbai City Collector and Magistrate Idzes Kundan. Vijayadevi has three school-going children. With the additional compensation from the government, the Kushwaha family hopes that life will be less of a struggle.